Carved Panel With Beveled Ornament

Tulunid or Abbasid, late 3rd-early 4th centuries AH / late 9th-early 10th centuries CE

Wood

W: 56 cm; H: 18 cm

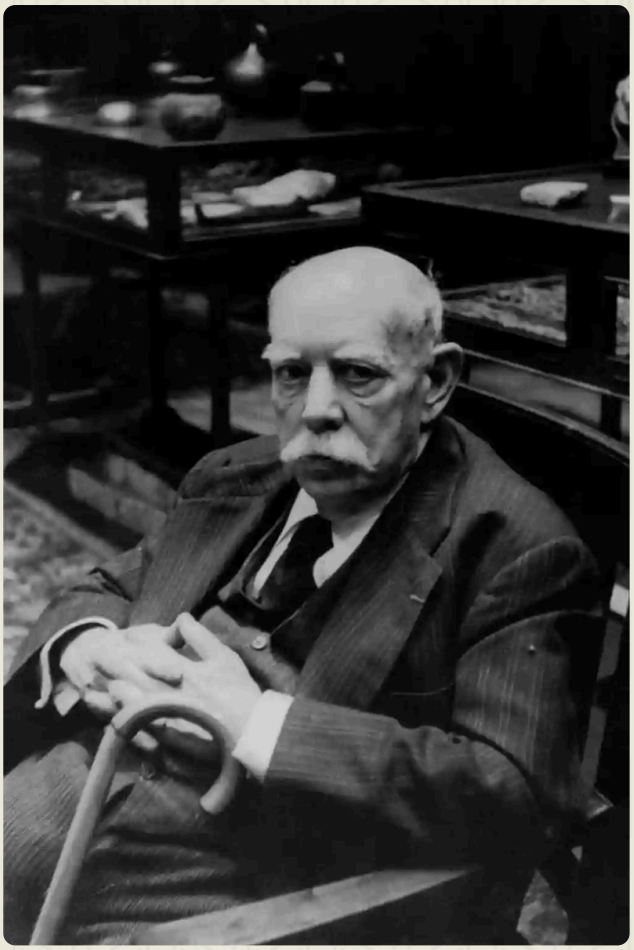
Hall 2

Inv. no. 4615



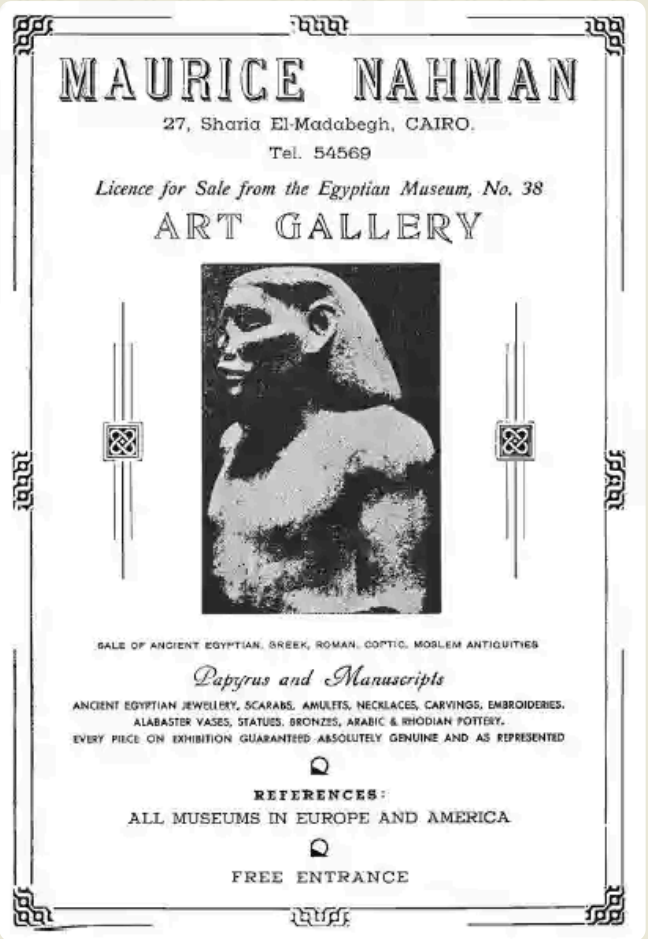
Piece no. 4615 © NADIM Foundation

This carved wooden fragment showcases the "beveled style," a technique of slanted, angled cuts that spread from the Abbasid capital of Samarra across the Islamic world. Undulating tendrils, buds, and heart-shaped leaves ripple across the surface, blurring the line between plant and abstract ornament. Faint traces of paint and a beaded "pearl" border, a motif borrowed from earlier Sassanian art, hint at the panel's original, more vivid appearance. Fragments like this one once decorated the walls, doors, or furnishings of buildings in medieval Cairo, most of which no longer survive intact or in-situ.



Maurice Nahman in his gallery, 1945. Brooklyn Museum.

This panel was acquired in 1917 from Maurice Nahman (1868-1948), a Jewish antiquarian who became one of the most consequential figures in the history of Egyptian antiquities dealing. Known in his lifetime as the "Lion of Cairo," Nahman ran his gallery from a house near the city's Downtown district for roughly six decades. There, alongside contemporaries like Nicolas George Tano (1866-1924) and Phocion Jean Tano (1898-1972), he cultivated relationships with excavators, local diggers, and fellow dealers that gave him access to an extraordinary range of material. Though best known for pharaonic antiquities, Nahman was equally instrumental in supplying Coptic and Islamic objects to institutions that had not yet formed dedicated departments for these fields, effectively helping to shape those disciplines as they emerged. Beyond visual art, scholars and collectors held him in high regard for his important papyrus collection and his rare Islamic manuscripts, which included exquisite royal volumes from the collection of the Ottoman sultan Abdulhamid II (r. 1876-1909). Through direct sales and generous donations, thousands of objects across the globe trace their provenance to Nahman, populating major collections at the Museum of Islamic Art in Cairo (MIA), the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the Louvre, the British Museum, and the Benaki Museum, to name a few.



Advertisemen by Maurice Nahman in le mondain egyptien, 1939

Nahman's legacy, however, remains double-edged. His commercial network preserved countless objects that might otherwise have been lost, but it also means most Nahman-sourced pieces, including this panel, carry no documented findspot. This absence of context is typical of the antiquities trade of the period, and it explains why the related beveled panel No. 4618, also acquired from Nahman, is a companion piece in more ways than one. Together, they reflect both the richness of medieval craftsmanship and the limits of what market-driven collecting can tell us today.

Bibliography:

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